EMUNOT VEDEOT: SAADIAH GAON'S BOOK OF BELIEFS AND OPINIONS

Light for the Righteous, Fire for the Wicked?

Given Monday 20 October 2025 · Emunot VeDeot, Essay 9:5

Sefer: Emunot VeDeot (The Book of Beliefs and Opinions) by Rav Saadia Gaon

Essay/Chapters: Essay 9 (Olam HaBa, The World to Come), Chapter 5

Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Monday series on Emunot VeDeot, Monday 20 October 2025, on Zoom

These notes are based on a transcript of the recording.

Where We Are in the Book

The first shiur after the long break of the Yamim Tovim, with the weekly schedule back: Monday Emunot VeDeot, Tuesday Rambam, Thursday Hilchot Shabbat. The Rabbi began with an overview of the whole sefer:

Essays	Theme
1 to 3	**HaKadosh Baruch Hu**: His attributes and how we relate to Him
4 to 6	**Revelation and our duties**: mitzvot and aveirot, tzaddikim and resha'im, prophecy, Torah, kinds of mitzvot
7 to 9	**The end of days**

Rav Saadia's picture of the end of days has several points other Rishonim disagree with:

- **Essays 7 and 8:** In this world, on this planet, Mashiach will come, and that era will last until the end of the 6,000 years. During it there will be a **techiyat hametim for specific people** in Am Yisrael.
- **Essay 9:** All of this leads to **Olam HaBa**, when **everyone who deserves it, Jewish or non-Jewish**, will be resurrected into a **new world**.

In Elul the class did **Chapters 1 to 4**: proofs for Olam HaBa from logic, from the Torah (with the question of why the Torah does not mention it explicitly) and from rabbinic tradition. But Saadia had not yet said **what Olam HaBa is**.

From Chapter 5 to the end of the essay (Chapter 11) he goes through **fourteen questions** on its nature. "He's the first one to actually discuss them," the Rabbi said, "and I'll tell you now straight up that some of his views are really quite radical." Some were not accepted at all.

Two points before starting

1. **The Rambam disagrees with almost every point.** "I was going through it: almost every single point that Saadia says, the Rambam disagrees with." The Rabbi promised to "iron out

the differences" point by point.
2. **Saadia takes a very literal view** of the pesukim about Olam HaBa, something the Rambam would later say was wrong.

And the crucial background: for Saadia, Olam HaBa is a **new world**. It is a "world to come" in the plain sense. It does not exist yet and will be created in the future. Mashiach and one stage of techiyat hametim happen here, in the world we know. Then there will be a final resurrection of all who deserve Olam HaBa, in a new world, where people will enjoy "the bliss or the torment of the world to come."

Chapter 5: Saadia's List of Questions

Saadia opens by recalling what he has already established. **The reward of soul and body cannot be separated**, because they are **one agent**. The soul and body are reunited to begin the new world. Since the body took part in the work and the effort, it must be rewarded equally.

The Rabbi noted that the **majority of Rishonim and Acharonim** follow Saadia that Olam HaBa is body and soul together. The **Rambam** does not: for him Olam HaBa is **soul alone**.

Now Saadia lists what still needs explaining:

1. and 2. **The nature of the reward** and **the nature of the punishment**.
2. **The place**: what environment will there be? Like this world or different?
3. **Time**: will there be time at all, and if so, for what purpose?
4. **Perpetuity**: what makes reward and punishment everlasting? Saadia holds that they are, and will explain why.
5. **Equality**: does everyone receive equal reward and equal punishment, or are there differences?
6. **Who deserves** everlasting reward and everlasting punishment.
7. **Meeting**: will those being rewarded meet each other? Will those being punished? Will the two groups meet?
8. **Service**: is there avodat Hashem, Torah and mitzvot, in Olam HaBa?
9. **Choice**: could people choose wrongly and sin there? "We're not talking about Messianic times. We're talking about the world to come."
10. **Reward for that service**: if there is service in Olam HaBa, where is its reward?

Saadia calls these "ten matters," though, as the Rabbi said, "it's not really ten," and in all there are fourteen points across Chapters 5 to 11. Some questions are straightforward; some are "really interesting." Is there service in Olam HaBa? "Surely you would say no, we serve in this world, and then that's it. But Saadia has a question about it." There are statements in Chazal here and there, but nothing entirely clear, and there are different approaches.

Tonight: points 1 and 2.

The Nature of Reward and Punishment: One Substance

Saadia says he mentioned this briefly in Chapter 4 when he quoted Chazal, but must now explain more:

שהגמול והעונש שני ענינים דקים יבראם אלהינו בעת השלום

Reward and punishment are two subtle things that our God will create at the time of repayment.

They are not here yet; they will be created at the end of time. Each person will receive what is fitting for him. And **both come from one substance**:

דומה לכח האש שורפת ומאירה

Like the power of fire, which burns and gives light.

This substance gives light to the righteous and not to the wicked, and burns the wicked and not the righteous. "Somehow the tzaddikim only get the light and not the heat of the fire, and somehow the resha'im only get the fire and not the light." Whether this is meant literally, the Rabbi said, we will see.

The sun in Malachi

כי הנה היום בא בער כתנור... וזרחה לכם יראי שמי שמש צדקה ומרפא בכנפיה (Malachi 3:19-20)

For behold, the day is coming, burning like an oven... and for you who fear My name, a sun of righteousness will shine, with healing in its wings.

For Saadia, the "day" that burns and the "sun of righteousness" are **one thing**. The Tanach sometimes uses **יום** to mean the sun. In Shoftim, **והיום רד מאד**, the day had gone far down, and **הנה נא רפה היום לערב**, the day has waned toward evening: in both, "day" means the sun, which was setting. So Malachi describes the future as a sun that gives both burning heat and bright light.

The difference from our sun

With the sun we know, heat and light **are mixed together and inseparable**. More light means more heat; less heat, less light. But the substance Hashem will create will gather **its light to the righteous and its heat to the wicked**. How? Saadia offers two possibilities:

1. A **special property** Hashem gives the substance itself.
2. It is the same light and heat, but Hashem **shields** the righteous from the heat and **hides** the light from the wicked.

Saadia says **the second is more likely**, because we have already seen it happen. In the plague of darkness:

ולכל בני ישראל היה אור במושבתם (Shemot 10:23)

But all the Children of Israel had light in their dwellings.

The Israelites lived **among** the Egyptians, as we see from **ושאלה אשה משכנתה ומגרת ביתה**, each woman would ask her neighbour (Shemot 3:22). Yet the Egyptians had darkness and the Israelites had light. Hashem can do it, and so in the future He will give only light to the tzaddikim and only heat and fire to the resha'im.

Why the Tanach calls reward light and punishment fire

On this basis Saadia explains why Scripture calls reward **light** and punishment **fire**:

כי עמך מקור חיים באורך נראה אור (Tehillim 36:10): with You is the source of life; in Your light we see light.

אור זרע לצדיק (Tehillim 97:11): light is sown for the righteous.

אור צדיקים ישמח (Mishlei 13:9): the light of the righteous rejoices.

להשיב נפשו מני שחת לאור באור החיים (Iyov 33:30): to bring his soul back from the pit, to be lit with the light of life.

And for the wicked:

והיה החסן לנערת ופעלו לניצוץ ובערו שניהם (Yeshayahu 1:31): the strong will be like chaff and his work a spark, and both will burn.

כי ערוך מאתמול תפתה (Yeshayahu 30:33): Tofteh has long been prepared. The Rabbi explained that **Tofet** was a place near Yerushalayim where idolaters burned their children as sacrifices; it returns at the end of the chapter.

ואש אכלה אהלי שחד (Iyov 15:34): fire will consume the tents of bribery.

תאכלהו אש לא נפח (Iyov 20:26): a fire not blown will consume him.

רוחכם אש תאכלכם (Yeshayahu 33:11): your spirit is a fire that will consume you.

ימטר על רשעים פחים אש וגפרית (Tehillim 11:6): He will rain coals, fire and brimstone on the wicked.

The Gemara behind it

Saadia does not cite it, but the Rabbi pointed out that this is an explicit Gemara (Avodah Zarah):

אמר רבי שמעון בן לקיש: אין גיהנם לעתיד לבא, אלא הקדוש ברוך הוא מוציא חמה מנרתיקה ומקדיר, רשעים נידונין בה וצדיקים מתרפאין בה

Reish Lakish said: there is no Gehinnom in the future. Rather, HaKadosh Baruch Hu takes the sun out of its sheath; the wicked are judged by it and the righteous are healed by it.

The wicked, from **כי הנה היום בא בער כתנור**; the righteous, from **וזרחה לכם יראי שמי שמש צדקה ומרפא בכנפיה**. And not only are they healed, **they delight in it**.

The Gemara speaks of **Gehinnom**. Saadia, as we will see at the end of the chapter, holds that **Gehinnom and Olam HaBa are the same thing**: Gehinnom is the name for the punishment of the World to Come. So he reads this Gemara as describing Olam HaBa itself, and he takes it "extremely literally."

The question of eternal punishment

In a later chapter Saadia will hold that both the light and the fire are **perpetual**, and he will ask himself the obvious question. Eternal reward for a lifetime of hard work makes sense. "But why would Hashem give perpetual punishment for those who sinned for 120 years? Even the worst person, you sin for 100 years, 120 years." The class will see his answer when they get there.

The key point for now: for Saadia, it seems, reward and punishment in Olam HaBa are **physical**. We have bodies and souls. The greatest reward is an intense light, "an intense sustenance of light"; for the wicked it is an intense fire, "and it goes on and on and on."

The Rabbi's Reflections

Photosynthesis and Yom Kippur

"The closest analogy I can think of for this, it actually works quite nicely": **photosynthesis**. Plants are subtle and live and grow from sunlight; the more sunshine and warmth, the more they grow. Olam HaBa will be a very subtle place where body and soul come together.

Or think of **Yom Kippur**. We do not eat or drink, the closest we come all year to being beyond the physical. That is why on Yom Kippur we say **ברוך שם כבוד מלכותו לעולם ועד** aloud. The Ramchal writes that it belongs to the angels, because it means that Hashem's sovereignty and unity are **seen**, manifest. All year we say **שמע ישראל** and believe Hashem is One, but we do not see His sovereignty spread out, so we say Baruch Shem quietly. On Yom Kippur we wean ourselves off the physical. Scientifically we are sustained by the food we ate the day before, "but on this level, we're being sustained through the light of Yom Kippur." Just as plants are sustained by light, so too the tzaddikim, who will not only be sustained but **נהנים מזיו**, will take pleasure in the radiance.

"I find this deeply troubling"

But what kind of pleasure is light? Sitting in the sun is lovely. "That's what we have holidays for." Imagine the most tropical island you can, where the weather is always perfect, not too hot, not too cold, sunshine all the time. Some people live like that all year round, moving between continents and climates. "But is that the climax? Is that it?"

Saadia, the Rabbi observed, speaks of **אור של השמש**, the light of a sun, not **אור של השם**, the light of Hashem. In describing the essence of reward and punishment he does not mention basking in the Shechinah, an idea that the Rambam, the Ramban, the Ramchal "and everyone" all echo. "I find this deeply troubling."

The Rambam's view

The Rambam certainly disagrees:

- There is **no body** in Olam HaBa, so sunshine means nothing to the soul.
- More deeply, the reward is far more elevated: **basking in the presence of HaKadosh Baruch Hu**, the light of Hashem.

"You could explain all of Saadia metaphorically and say when he's referring to the light of the sun, he means the light of Hashem. I don't think he means that. He doesn't say that." Nor is that the thrust of the rest of the chapter.

Questions from Mark

"Light in whose presence?" Mark asked whether this is just pure light or pure fire, since Hashem is not mentioned. "That's what it seems to be."

Can one person have both? Most people are not perfect, Mark argued. They could have light for the good they did and fire for the wrong, like the hot embarrassment one feels after doing something wrong. The Rabbi called it "a very, very important and good point." Most of us are beinonim. Do we spend some years in fire and then move to light? Saadia deals with this a couple of chapters later, when he discusses perpetuity and mitzvot and aveirot.

What happens to someone who dies today? If Olam HaBa does not exist yet, where is the soul now? According to Saadia, there is no account of it. Souls are suspended, waiting, "because he says very clearly, these things will only be created at the time of the end." The Rambam's view of Gan Eden and Gehinnom would be the subject of the Tuesday shiur the next night.

Living on Light: Moshe Rabbeinu

The next paragraph shows again how physical Saadia's picture is. If Olam HaBa is body and soul, and the only reward is light, and the Gemara quoted in Chapter 4 says there is **no eating or drinking** there, how will bodies live?

The answer, says Saadia, is **Moshe Rabbeinu**, whom Hashem kept alive three times for forty days without food or drink:

ואשב בהר ארבעים יום וארבעים לילה לחם לא אכלתי ומים לא שתיתי (Devarim 9:9)

I remained on the mountain forty days and forty nights; I ate no bread and drank no water.

How did he live? **By the light Hashem placed on his face**:

ומשה לא ידע כי קרן עור פניו (Shemot 34:29)

Moshe did not know that the skin of his face was radiant.

That, says Saadia, is the sign by which we understand how the righteous will live in Olam HaBa: by light, without food. This was the wonder Hashem promised Moshe: **נגד כל עמך אעשה נפלאת אשר לא נבראו בכל הארץ ובכל הגוים** (Shemot 34:10).

The same verse, opposite readings

Saadia then reads the famous verse:

עין לא ראתה אלהים זולתך יעשה למחכה לו (Yeshayahu 64:3)

No eye has seen, O God, except You, what He will do for those who wait for Him.

For Saadia, what no eye has seen is **a body living with no food**. Moshe saw it, but no public eye has.

The Rabbi pointed out that the **Rambam uses precisely this verse to prove the opposite**: that Olam HaBa cannot be anything physical. Sun and fire we have experienced, maybe not at the same intensity, but we have. If no eye has seen it, it cannot be sunshine or fire. "Completely divergent, completely different views."

Burning Without Being Consumed

Another physical question. If the wicked have bodies and their punishment is fire, fire eventually consumes what it burns. How can anyone be punished **perpetually** in fire?

We have no precedent from experience, says Saadia, and because we have none, Scripture states it explicitly:

כי תולעתם לא תמות ואשם לא תכבה (Yeshayahu 66:24)

Their worm will not die and their fire will not be extinguished.

So their souls must be preserved in their bodies in a subtle way, so that they feel the painful heat without being destroyed. And the same must be true of the righteous: their constant intense light must not harm them. "You think about it, you sit at the beach for too long, you get damaged."

Saadia adds an analogy: when people want to punish someone for a long time, they give him food and drink so that he survives the punishment. "It's ironic. I'm trying to punish you, but I'm

giving you food and giving you medicine. Why? Because I want to punish you." But they do so **within** nature. The Creator acts **above** nature and preserves the person without food.

"Unbelievable," said the Rabbi. "Scary, no? If this is what reward and punishment is, it's pretty scary."

He added a verse Saadia could have brought: **the burning bush**.

וירא והנה הסנה בער באש והסנה איננו אכל (Shemot 3:2)

He looked, and behold, the bush was burning with fire, and the bush was not consumed.

The same idea: burning, but never consumed.

Why "Gan Eden" and "Gehinnom"

Finally, Saadia explains the names.

Gan Eden. The reward is called Gan Eden because there is nothing in this world more honoured than **the garden where Hashem placed Adam**, which the class had just read about that Shabbat in Bereishit. It is the closest image of bliss we have, so whenever Scripture wants to describe something wonderful it uses it: **כגן עדן הארץ לפניו** (Yoel 2:3).

Gehinnom. The punishment is called Gehinnom because Scripture calls it **Tofteh**, a place near the Beit HaMikdash:

לכן הנה ימים באים נאם ה' ולא יאמר עוד התפת וגיא בן הנם כי אם גיא ההרגה וקברו בתפת מאין מקום (Yirmiyahu 7:32)

Therefore days are coming, says Hashem, when it will no longer be called Tofet or the Valley of Ben Hinnom, but the Valley of Slaughter.

Tofet was where they offered human sacrifices and burned them. It stood in **גיא בן הנם**, the valley of a man named Hinnom. Because Tofet's fire was in that valley, "Gei Ben Hinnom" became the name for burning, shortened to **Gehinnom**. It could equally have been called Tofet. Just as Gan Eden is the image for anything good, Tofet is the image for anything terrible: **והיו בתי ירושלם ובתי מלכי יהודה כמקום התפת הטמאים** (Yirmiyahu 19:13).

Gan Eden and Gehinnom are Olam HaBa

"The remarkable thing," the Rabbi said, is that for Saadia **Gan Eden and Gehinnom are synonymous with Olam HaBa**. That answers Mark's question: this is why Saadia gives no description of what happens between a person's death today and Olam HaBa, at the end of the 6,000 years, which Saadia takes literally.

The Rambam and other Rishonim see it differently. The **Ramban** agrees with Saadia that Olam HaBa is body and soul, but **not** that it is Gan Eden and Gehinnom. What "basically everyone holds" is that Gan Eden and Gehinnom are **temporary places** where people receive reward or punishment according to their deeds **until** Olam HaBa. The Rambam and Ramban disagree about what Olam HaBa is, but agree that it is not Gan Eden and Gehinnom.

Summary of Chapter 5

Question	Saadia	Rambam
What are reward and punishment?	One created substance: **light** for the righteous, **fire** for the wicked	**Closeness to Hashem** or **distance** from Him
Why does Scripture say light and fire?	Because that is literally what they are	Light is closeness; fire is the embarrassment of being far from Hashem
How are bodies sustained?	By light, like Moshe on the mountain	There is no body and no sustenance
How can fire burn forever?	Hashem preserves the body above nature	No question: no body
Gan Eden and Gehinnom	**The same as** Olam HaBa	Preliminary stages before Olam HaBa

Saadia will go further later in the essay, describing levels in Olam HaBa and seven levels of Gehinnom, with different kinds of fire.

Discussion: Was Saadia Speaking Literally?

The Rabbi asked why Saadia, of all people, would hold such a literal view. Perhaps he kept to basic terms so as not to push people away, since the idea of fire and light was so ingrained. But Saadia was willing "so many times" to go against the masses. Remember how strongly he fought for **the incorporeality of God**, castigating those who believed otherwise, at a time (the 900s) when many held a corporeal view. Today we take incorporeality for granted because of the Rambam. In Essay 7, too, Saadia set out when one may interpret the Torah metaphorically: when the literal reading goes against reason. "So if he really did believe that the sun and the light are just closeness to Hashem or being far and embarrassed from Hashem, you would have expected Saadia to say something like that." Instead he doubles down later with seven levels of Gehinnom.

A participant added that this makes it even more problematic: the book is written for someone coming to learn, and this would have been exactly the place to explain what is metaphorical, as the Moreh Nevuchim does a couple of centuries later.

The Rabbi noted that Saadia also took **techiyat hametim** (Essay 7, which began as a separate pamphlet he wrote because of the confusion around it) and **Mashiach** (Essay 8, with the nations arriving in different carriages and modes of transport) quite literally. The final, tenth essay, encouraging good behaviour, was a separate work added to the book.

"So there's elements of him which seem sometimes to take things very metaphorically, certainly at the beginning of the book, in the first two essays." But here "he seems to be taking everything" literally, and the coming chapters describe quite a physical environment. "I don't have a clear answer. I think it's quite difficult to say that this is all metaphorical."

it's very, very difficult. "But it's part of the sefer, we learn it. We don't always ,**מאוד מאוד קשה** understand all of the Chachamim, and the Chachamim are not monolithic. But that's the view of

".Saadia. I ascribe to the school of the Rambam

Next week: **Chapter 6, the place and the time of Olam HaBa**.

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